YOUNG ADULT

DESI YA SHOWS TO WATCH

Recent productions that made a splash, some of which have ongoing seasons



COLLEGE ROMANCE *(SonyLIV)*

This show by The Viral Fever about three friends and their adventures in the classroom was picked up by SonyLIV where it has had a run of three more seasons.

BIG GIRLS DONT CRY *(Prime Video)*

Aneet Padda may be known as *Saiyaara*'s Vaani now, but this coming-of-age drama set in an all-girls boarding school first made her visible.





FLAMES *(Prime Video)*

Rajjo (Ritvik Sahore) & Ishita (Tanya Manitkala) have kept audiences hooked, anchoring a romance blooming in a Delhi tuition centre.



HOSTEL DAZE *(Prime Video)*

Before Adarsh Gourav broke through with *The White Tiger*, he was already a familiar face for playing Ankit in this The Viral Fever show, about a small group of hostellers navigating college life.



CLASS *(Netflix)*

Season one was hailed for its bold depiction of life in a posh private school, portrayed through a talented cast of newcomers.

captured a generation's mood and managed to stay relevant over time," says Tanya Bami, series head, Netflix India. "At its heart, it's a simple, feel-good story about young people trying to find their place in the world where careers, romance and technology come at you at the same time." That it has made stars out of Prajakta Koli and Rohit Saraf, who are now synonymous with their characters Dimple and Rishi, is proof of the show's enduring appeal.

The larger media landscape has a role to play too. Nikhil Madhok, director & head of originals, Prime Video, India, admits that he didn't anticipate *TSITP*'s love triangle between a 21-year-old woman and two brothers drawing such a strong following in India. But once the show took off, he understood why the audience—mostly Gen Z and millennial women—were taking to it. "If you look at the choices the YA audience is presented with, from a storytelling perspective, our movies have largely focused on hyper masculine stories targeted primarily at men and TV tends to focus on family drama and what happens to a woman after marriage," he says. "Not enough stories are being created for the 16-25 years group. For them relatability is very important. Is it authentic to the experience they are having? Are the stories reflective of the same complexes and challenges they are facing?"

THE NEED FOR INDIAN STORIES

That's an area in which Indian productions have been sorely lacking. While there have been offerings with varying success like *Mismatched*, *Kho Gaye Hum Kahan* (a social media-centred romantic drama) and *CTRL* (about an influencer couple and their breakup), few ventures have found the monumental success of foreign productions. Sonal Kabi, director & head of marketing, Prime Video, India, notes that for Indian youth, "YA content is more than entertainment, it's a window into global youth culture, one they're not just consuming, but co-creating. When young audiences connect, they don't just watch—they participate, share and make it their own. We've seen it first-hand: the 'Team Conrad vs Team Jeremiah' frenzy didn't stop at the finale, it sparked thriving fandom communities."

Like 30-year-old Divya Gupta, a content creator who attended the *TSITP* finale screening. "There are love triangles, these OMG [oh my god] and will-it-happen moments, feelings and chemistry that keep you hooked," she says about the appeal of shows like *TSITP* and K-dramas. "I don't see any Indian shows able to replicate that."

Part of the problem is that despite the demand, there's little supply by Indian screenwriters. "We have been actively looking for ideas, but we don't get enough YA pitches," says Madhok. There's also the fear of producing scripts that seem out of touch. He adds, "We have to make sure that when these stories come to us, they are not a 40-year-old's vision of what Gen Z is like." One way to plug the gap could be finding India's own answer to YA author Jenny Han, whose books have spawned hugely successful adaptations, including *TSITP*.

It's anyone's guess as to when more local stories will dominate the YA genre on TV and film, but in the meantime, Indian viewers have plenty to choose from, with *Maxton Hall* being the choice of the season (trending at #6 on Amazon Prime India) and the final season of *Stranger Things* just around the corner. ■